BEST OF THREE.

“BEST OF THREE?”

Stark silence followed, neither party prepared for such a risky move.

“Is that really the most sensible idea? You're not exactly on a winning streak.”

“BEST OF THREE.”

Silence resumed, grim determination set in their features.

“..Okay.”

“Coulda do wid a education like you heh-heh” added the only spectator; one man witness to possibly the most important bet in the city of Atruhfi's profound history.

“Indeed.”

The tension rose; and if it wasn't midway through Autumn in Atruhfi, two out of the three gamblers would have had foreheads drenched in sweat. Did the third even have a forehead? It wasn't visible, covered by his dark cloak. All that was visible of him was part of a pale, distinctive, bone-like skin tone.

“He is hidin' 'cuz he's scared he's gonna lose” had whispered the spectator – the lankier of the two. His starved figure was emphasised by his atrocious posture. A slump of bone and flesh. The mysterious fellow leaned forward unexpectedly quickly, making the street rat flinch, to place a card on top of the pile that was positioned in the centre of the gamblers. Ace of Spades.

“YOU ARE AN EDUCATED MAN?” interrogated the stranger in a deep, calm voice. Somehow, even though his voice was monotone, he managed to demonstrate a form of curiosity that made it seem like he already knew the answer to his own enquiry.

“Vaglanek is cleverer then you will eva be” began the spectator “saw lots, done lots, teached even more than dat.”

“Yes, thank you Jak-sir.” acknowledged Vaglane, although he clearly was no sir. Vaglane didn't bother correcting Jak these days since he knew of the strange customs held dear to him. For one, it was essential to end everyone's name with “k” as in Jak's own – You see, Jak was completely ordinary. Yes, completely ordinary... For a beggar.

“I am indeed an 'educated man'. Not that it ended well for me, as you can see, I'm on the streets just the same as any other gentleman.” Vaglane knew he wasn't an ordinary street rat, but he wasn't at all used to being questioned about his origins. Generally, on the dimly lit streets of Atruhfi, you met regulars and learnt to tolerate their habits. You never asked why they are what they are. He added another card from his hand to the stack. Seven of Clubs.

“SO I SUPPOSE THERE'S A TALE BEHIND YOU." Continued the stranger. Vaglane 's vision adjusted slightly to the darkness and could now see a permanent grin on the stranger's face (as well as Jak subtly peering behind himself in search for his tail). He was not an ordinary passer-by. He was as strange as Jak, with the intellect of Vaglane himself.

“I associated myself with the wrong people. Closed minded, ignorant, rich folk. It's not like on the streets – like I tell Jak – and it's not like you can avoid them when you are busy kissing their behinds in order to get the correct funding for the type of research that I wanted to carry out.” Jak listened intently, despite hearing the same sentence far too many times. “But once you've accepted that you won't get another chance to grasp a new philosophical book in your hand, that makes you question your very existence, you learn to enjoy the little things once more. Nevertheless, it's about the here and now. And right now, you're trying to distract me, I bet. A cheap trick. It won't work; I'm as focused as ever.” There was no chance that Vaglane would let this man beat him. The stakes were too high. This was the type of battle between minds that you only discover from a rumour someone was told by a friend's friend of a friend's uncle's cousin's landlord's daughter (usually accompanied by intense background music).

“NOT AT ALL.” He insisted, placing yet another card from his hand down onto the ground. King of Clubs. Despite being seated to the side of the filthy cobblestone road, underneath a gas street lamp that stood in solitude, they could just about make out the faces in front of them, and the cards below them.

“JUST CURIOUS.”

“Well if we're being curious, how about you tell me your life story.” Intruded Vaglane, with fair reason to do so.

“I HAVEN'T MUCH TO SAY ON THAT TOPIC.” He grinned. Vaglane thought he heard an echo of a soft chuckle, but perhaps he'd misheard. He placed yet another card on the, now, leaning tower of playing cards.

“SNAP!” they both yelled simultaneously as they placed their hands onto the card that had just been played. (That's how you settled matches that were too close to call.) Another King lay beneath their hands; King of Hearts. Jak's mindless expression suddenly became that of confusion. Shock. His jaw left hanging. Vaglane slowly removed his hand from on top of stranger's. He'd lost. Jak had never seen such a thing. Such speed. But that was insignificant to the loser the moment Vaglane realised what his hand had been resting upon. A bone structure with no flesh attached. This man's hand was not a hand. It was simply bone. Bones. Skeletons. Dead. Death. It was Death. Death himself.

“I WIN” Death grinned. He lifted his black hood from over his face to reveal a skull, smirking at the wannabe gambling duo. Both beggars were speechless, unable to comprehend the events that had unfolded before their eyes. They had eyes. Death didn't. Death had bottomless, black holes

that most likely transported you to another dimension if you glared at him for too long – perhaps that's what the hood is for, thought Vaglane, to prevent such disasters.

“D-Death?” stuttered Vaglane “Why are you here?”

“Deathk? Nah he just ain't eatin' nuff. Skinny thing you are.” Jak interrupted, but wasn't acknowledged by either Death nor Vaglane.

“It's not our time, is it?” Vaglane nervously put forward the notion he dreaded most. Although he was intrigued and excited by the concept of dying, he wasn't ready to experience it just yet.

“NO.” He concluded by recalling fond moments “I'VE JUST ALWAYS LOVED SNAP.”

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